



Guide to the IELTS Academic test

Your short guide to achieving your target score with the IELTS Academic test

Do you want to study abroad at a prestigious English-speaking university? What about developing expertise in a field that excites you? The IELTS Academic test can help you realise these opportunities.

What is the IELTS Academic test?

The IELTS Academic test serves as an international benchmark for measuring English language ability in academic contexts, such as universities or colleges.

What is the purpose of the IELTS Academic test?

To gain acceptance into higher education institutions that teach in English, students often need to pass a recognised English proficiency test like the IELTS Academic test.

Who needs the IELTS Academic test?

Whether you want to study engineering, medicine, business, or any other field, the IELTS Academic test will benefit anyone wanting to study at an English-speaking university.

Why choose IELTS over the alternatives?

When it comes to English proficiency tests, IELTS is the gold standard for those looking to prove their English ability. With over 3.5 million test takers every year, IELTS is the most popular English language assessment globally. Here's why millions prefer the IELTS Academic test each year:

Global recognition and acceptance

IELTS is globally recognised as the leading English test for academic study. With over 12,000 organisations (not only educational institutions) around the world accepting IELTS results as evidence of English ability, it's your top choice no matter where you want to study.

Fair and holistic language testing

IELTS offers a well-rounded examination, ensuring a fair and accurate evaluation of your language proficiency across various dimensions.

Focus on all key skills

Beyond just an evaluation, the IELTS Academic test prepares you for the rigours of higher education by honing all crucial language skills: listening, reading, writing, and speaking. This holistic approach sets you up for fluency and academic success.

Universal applicability

IELTS is relevant everywhere English is spoken, as it accepts both UK and US English. This makes it easier for test takers to use the English they know, preparing them for global conversations.

Flexibility and choice

Depending on your location, you can choose between IELTS on paper or IELTS on computer, both of which take place in a test centre. We also offer the option to take the new IELTS Online Academic test.

One Skill Retake

When you take IELTS on computer with the British Council you also have access to One Skill Retake. This means you can retake a specific section of the test, rather than the entire test, saving time and money if you only want to improve your score in a single section. Check [here](#) to see if One Skill Retake is available in your country.





What's in the IELTS Academic test

The IELTS Academic test is 2 hours and 45 minutes long and consists of four sections: Listening, Reading, Writing, and Speaking. Here's an overview of each section:

Listening section

- **Duration:** 30 minutes + 10 minutes for transferring answers (this additional time isn't required for IELTS on computer)
- **Format:** Four audio recordings of people speaking, with a range of diverse accents
- **Types of questions:** Multiple choice, matching, diagram labelling, sentence completion
- **What you might hear:** Everyday conversations, monologues, educational discussions, lectures on academic subjects

Reading section

- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Format:** Three long reading passages ranging from factual information to discussion pieces and analysis
- **Types of questions:** 40 questions
- **What you might read:** Texts are from sources like books, journals, magazines, and newspapers

Writing section

- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Format:** Two tasks
- **Task Specifics:**
 - **Task 1:** Describe, explain, or summarise data or processes
 - **Task 2:** Write an essay in response to a point of view, argument, or problem

Speaking section

- **Duration:** 10–14 minutes
- **Format:** Face-to-face interview
- **Sections:**
 - **Part 1:** General questions about familiar topics (4–5 mins)
 - **Part 2:** Speak about a specific topic on a card (up to 2 mins)
 - **Part 3:** Discuss abstract ideas related to the Part 2 topic (4–5 mins)
 - The Speaking assessment is recorded and, in some locations, may be scheduled on a different day

What do IELTS Academic scores mean?

Band score	Skill level	Description
Band 9	Expert user	You have a full operational command of the language. Your use of English is appropriate, accurate and fluent, and you show complete understanding.
Band 8	Very good user	You have a fully operational command of the language with only occasional inaccuracies and inappropriate usage. You may misunderstand some things in unfamiliar situations. You handle complex, detailed argumentation well.
Band 7	Good user	You have an operational command of the language, though with occasional inaccuracies, inappropriate usage and misunderstandings in some situations. Generally, you handle complex language well and understand detailed reasoning.
Band 6	Competent user	Generally, you have an effective command of the language despite some inaccuracies, inappropriate usage and misunderstandings. You can use and understand fairly complex language, particularly in familiar situations.
Band 5	Modest user	You have a partial command of the language and cope with overall meaning in most situations, although you are likely to make many mistakes. You should be able to handle basic communication in your own field.
Band 4	Limited user	Your basic competence is limited to familiar situations. You frequently show problems in understanding and expression. You are not able to use complex language.
Band 3	Extremely limited user	You convey and understand only general meaning in very familiar situations. There are frequent breakdowns in communication.
Band 2	Intermittent user	You have great difficulty understanding spoken and written English.
Band 1	Non-user	You cannot use the language except for a few isolated words.
Band 0	Did not attempt the test	You did not answer the questions.

Don't believe these IELTS myths

There are a lot of misconceptions about IELTS that can impact how you prepare for the test. Here's the truth on the most common IELTS myths.

1. IELTS is more difficult than other tests

Neither IELTS or TOEFL is objectively harder than the other, but IELTS has helped millions of people achieve their dreams of studying and working abroad, showing its practical approach and achievable standards.

2. Your accent will affect your score

Wrong. IELTS is an unbiased language proficiency test, and examiners don't favour any accent. What truly matters is that you communicate clearly and use precise vocabulary.

3. There are different IELTS tests for different countries

There's only one IELTS Academic test, and it's standardised globally. Regardless of where you take it, the test remains the same, so there's no advantage or disadvantage based on your location.

4. Complex sentences guarantee better scores

Complexity isn't the key to success in IELTS. Using complex words is acceptable, but ensure your sentences remain clear and comprehensible. Simplicity often leads to higher scores.

5. More writing equals higher scores

Quality is better than quantity in IELTS Writing. Writing long essays won't necessarily boost your score, but it might introduce more errors. Stick to the word limit and focus on clarity and coherence.

6. There's a single 'passing' score

The IELTS score you need to achieve will vary depending on your goals and the institution you're applying to. Each university sets its own score requirements, so there's no one-size-fits-all passing score. Research your institution's requirements to determine the score you need.

7. IELTS is impossible to prepare for

Preparation is key to success. The British Council offers many resources to help you prepare and succeed on the test, including practice tests, study materials, and courses.

8. You can't retake IELTS

You can retake IELTS as many times as you want. The British Council also offers "One Skill Retake" for those who take IELTS on computer, where you can improve one section of the exam while keeping your other scores the same.

Preparing for the IELTS Academic test

At the British Council, we offer everything you need to prepare for your test. Our various resources, both free and paid, will help your practice and sharpen your key English skills — so that you can take the test with confidence.

Like anything worth doing, IELTS success can be achieved through hard work and preparation. At the British Council, we offer many test preparation resources to help you understand the test format, improve your English skills, and build your confidence.

IELTS Ready:

Our comprehensive IELTS test preparation offering, which includes study resources, practice tests, and masterclasses. *IELTS Ready* comprises two options: *IELTS Ready Member*, with study resources and practice tools free of charge, when you subscribe, and *IELTS Ready Premium*, which provides a personalised study plan and 40+ practice tests, complimentary upon booking your test with the British Council. Book early to make the most of these resources.

Practice tests

These practice tests will introduce you to the IELTS test format, and help you become familiar with the types of tasks you will be asked to undertake on test day.

IELTS tips and videos

Tips from past test takers aimed at improving your performance. Practice materials can be found in each section.

IELTS Coach

Group classes and one-to-one sessions with an expert English language teacher. Coaching is available 24/7 and can focus on improving specific problem areas.

EnglishScore tutors

Personalised online tutoring from certified teachers. These one-on-one classes will help you prepare for your test whether it's a week, or a few months away.

IELTS Face-to-face courses

Courses designed to help prepare you for your IELTS test, covering all four skills: Listening, Reading, Writing and Speaking. Check your local British Council website to see if these courses are available in your country.



Why you should choose the British Council for your IELTS Academic test

With decades of experience and a global reputation for quality, the British Council is the preferred choice for millions of IELTS test-takers. Here's why you should choose the British Council for your IELTS Academic test:

Global recognition

With 90 years of experience in English education and a presence in 100+ countries, the British Council is a globally recognised authority in English language teaching and assessment. Our expertise ensures you're in safe hands.

Unmatched preparation support

We provide more free preparation than any other test provider through our *IELTS Ready* offering, which includes interactive activities, expert masterclasses, and over 40 practice tests. Make sure you book early to make the most of these resources.

Trusted and transparent

IELTS is jointly run by the British Council and our services are trusted by over 12,000 organisations worldwide.

Flexibility and choice

Depending on your location, you can choose between IELTS on paper or IELTS on computer. We also offer the option to take the new IELTS Online academic test that can be taken from the comfort of your home.

Simple booking and testing

From booking your test to receiving your results, we have systems in place to guide you every step of the way.

Convenient dates and locations

All official British Council IELTS test centres are modern, comfortable, and conveniently located. Test dates are scheduled throughout the year, letting you pick the date that best suits your calendar.

Stress-free experience

From the moment you book your test to the day you get your results, we ensure a seamless, supportive, and transparent experience.

Professional and friendly staff

Our classes are led by highly trained educational specialists. IELTS tests are run by experienced staff who ensure your test day runs smoothly.

Steps for completing the IELTS Academic test

1

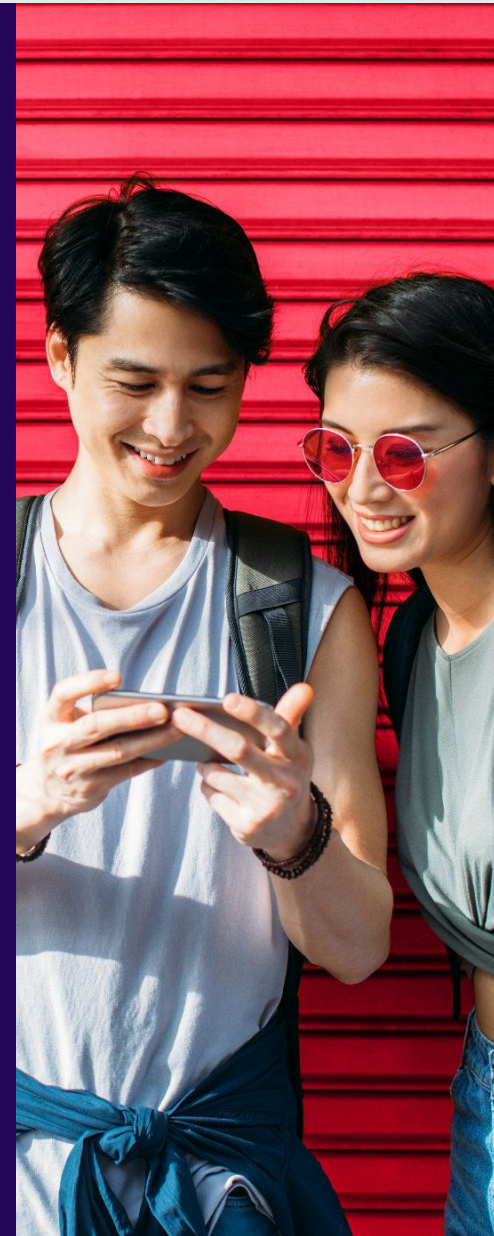
Book the test

Choose how to take your IELTS Academic test and [book online](#). Take your test at an official test centre, from the comfort of your home, or any private space with a reliable internet connection.

2

Confirm test times

Receive a confirmation of booking detailing the test start time and venue address. The Speaking Section of your test will be scheduled on the same day or within a 7-day window of your other test.



3

Prepare for the test

Study with *IELTS Ready*, IELTS Coach, and the many [free resources we provide](#).



4

Take the test

Put your hard work to good use by taking the test. To prove your identity, don't forget to bring the same ID you used to register for the IELTS Academic test.

5

Get the results

Your results will be available 13 days after your IELTS on paper test or 1–5 days after your IELTS on computer test. You will receive an official Test Report Form (TRF).

6

Apply with your results

Use the TRF to apply to the higher education institute of your choice.





IELTS success stories

Hear from English learners like you who have worked with the British Council to succeed on their IELTS and secure a place at their university of choice.

Faraja, Tanzania

“

The British Council has really helped me improve my speaking and listening skills. I recommend you take IELTS with them.

Chiranjivi, Nepal

“

I took IELTS on computer, which was a really awesome experience! In the Reading test, I felt really relaxed since I could view the passage and questions side by side. If you ask me, typing on the keyboard is much better, as you can delete text easily, making your written work look immaculate.

Muhammad, Pakistan

“

I received everything I needed for taking my test by email as soon as I'd booked my test. The practice tests and videos made me less nervous as I knew what to expect on the day. I found the study materials easy to use. I also attended the IELTS webinars, which were very helpful.

Frequently asked questions



Which IELTS test will I need to take for university acceptance?

Most universities accept the IELTS Academic test, but make sure to find out which score your chosen universities require.

What is a good IELTS score for university applications?

Universities typically require scores ranging from 6.0 (competent user) to 7.0 (good user), though higher scores are often advantageous. Make sure to check the specific requirements of the university you're interested in.

How long will my IELTS score be valid?

Your IELTS score remains valid for two years from the date of the test.

When will I receive my IELTS test results?

Your Test Report Form will be posted to you 13 days after your IELTS on paper test or 1-5 days after your IELTS on computer test. Some test centres also provide SMS alerts and an Online Results Service. Keep your Test Report Form in a secure place as you only receive one copy.

How do I send a copy of the Test Report Form to a university?

We can send up to five additional copies of your Test Report Form directly to institutions you are applying to. If you would like us to do this, please include the relevant addresses on the Test taker portal within two years of taking the test. Some universities or institutions have subscribed to electronic download of scores, so please check with your local test centre before sending them your results.

Where can I find IELTS practice tests and other preparation material?

You can find [free practice tests and other preparation material](#) on our site.

Taking the next step

Don't put off your dreams any longer. Book your IELTS Academic test with the British Council now, and take an important step toward your future.